

Chalance is Cool: Overcoming Barriers to Student Voices in 2026 Midterms

“He’s too nonchalant.” My friend whispers this statement into my ear as we cross the quad, debating potential partners for an upcoming assignment. She was claiming a fellow student couldn’t care less about the project. I thought about it for a moment and quickly agreed. Like many students, I couldn’t go through another horrific group project ordeal. We needed someone with chalance: someone that cared passionately about the class, who ate, slept, and breathed engineering. Luckily at Duke, most of the students are indeed chalant, and have deep passions for the change they strive to impose.

Although not an official word, chalance is one my friends and I use obsessively. We define chalance as the act of caring deeply about something. As a student, it is incredibly inspiring to witness the chalance of peers; the way in which they dedicate discipline, diligence, and delight is invigorating.

It is undeniable that the broader student population cares about their [communities, political issues, and social change](#). In terms of civic action and voting, most students are avid contributors to democracy. Contrary to popular belief, it’s not the nonchalance of students or “voting apathy” that prevents them from voting; rather the incredibly complex voting system that suppresses students.

The portrayal of nonchalance and voter apathy among students is a harmful stereotype, especially with the 2026 midterm elections fast approaching. Democrats and Republicans are scrambling to redistrict states in their favor, teeing up an all-out battle for control of the House and Senate. With Republicans currently holding a majority in both, Democrats are hoping to harness [past history](#) and capitalize on Trump’s low approval ratings to flip critical seats. As Democrats look to cash in on the youth vote, college students will undoubtedly play a key role in the midterms.

In the 2022 midterms, [31.3%](#) of students voted, reflecting a historical upward trend. Student voter registration rates increased from [73.3% in 2018 to 76.1% in 2022](#). Moreover, youth voting impacted the outcome of close elections in 2022 when [John Fetterman](#) narrowly won the Pennsylvania Senate, mainly propelled to the finish line by youth.

Despite the undeniable importance of students, their voices often go unheard. Voting on college campuses is distinct from residential communities. Students are likely not in their hometown, possibly not even in their home state, with [20%](#) of students attending college out-of-state, leading to unfamiliarity and discouragement. Students may have to wait in long lines, are less likely to have driver’s licenses, procrastinate tasks (like voting), confuse voting procedures, and live on a campus that is split among [multiple voting districts](#). The United States voting system is

putting Americans through an obstacle course they aren't trained for. Complete with boulders and hoops that we don't know how to get around. Americans are not conditioned to reach the finish line. A promise of victory, of exercising civil rights and democracy, is held out, but quickly snatched away. For those without cars or higher education degrees, with full-time jobs and kids, and low income and non-English speaking individuals, victory is unreachable.

When I turned 18 and had the right to vote, the system still managed to push me down. Friends, classes, basketball games, midterms, more basketball games, and clubs were just a small percentage of the everyday routine. Registering to vote turned from an easy, unquestionable necessity to a sluggish, back-of-mind task. Thoughts of doubt slowly crept in. *Do I need to register to vote? Will my vote make a difference?* It is sentiments like these that slowly chip away at the building blocks of democracy.

However, when I walked into my dining hall one day, I surprisingly found my roommate, a member of Duke Votes, with a clipboard and pen, telling me exactly what to do. With a flick of her pen, some checkmarks, and a signature, I was registered to vote! It felt like witchcraft. It wasn't. It was a clear, decisive, and straightforward way to get students to vote. She set her table up in an area of high foot traffic, resources in hand, complete with a succinct elevator pitch. My roommate was chalcant in all the right ways. She found students, trained them, taught them the art of form-filling-out, all with little effort from everyone. Student voting doesn't have to be inherently difficult with the help of collective action.

With my roommate acting as a prime example, today's students are the next generation of leaders. Inspiringly, [students across campuses](#) are invigorating the voting movement. However, students also possess feelings of uncertainty, fear, and powerlessness. [57%](#) of students said that their vote didn't impact the 2024 presidential election, and [70%](#) of students are concerned about America's future as a democracy.

Many guides for university administrations and civic engagement groups exist. However, these documents are tediously long, which are not conducive for the average student. Taking inspiration from [Jon Scheyer](#), the fight against student voter suppression can be akin to a basketball game. First, form a team of key stakeholders who are part of the cause: election officials, campus administrators, and student leaders.

Next, develop a gameplan through creating various resources on polling places, ID requirements, and registration. Identify key channels of communication and create a timeline marking specific early voting dates. When the first key date approaches, it's game time. Employ student volunteers at voting centers, work with election officials to establish an [on-campus vote center](#) in states where it is legal, continue constant communication, and facilitate voting through plain language instructions.

After every election cycle, dissect and analyze what happened. How many students registered? How many actually voted? Figure out what went wrong and how you can fix it for the next election cycle.

In short, be chalant. Outwardly empower the communities and peers around you. Be the voracious voice vibrating through the democratic system. Although you might have a physics midterm that same week, the other midterms, the midterm *elections*, are imminent, and a game plan must be made.